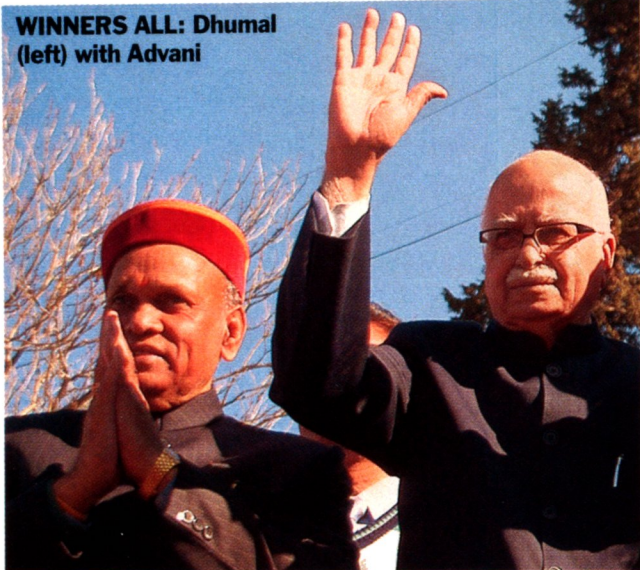


WINNERS ALL: Dhumal (left) with Advani



ANIL DAYAL

Riding the Saffron Wave

SHIMLA It was the most heart-warming New Year gift that BJP could have asked for. Buoyed by Narendra Modi's anti-incumbency-defying feat in Gujarat, the saffron party wrested power from the Congress in Himachal Pradesh in less than a week, sending jitters in the UPA dispensation at the Centre.

The symbolism of BJP being on cloud nine was evident from the boastful choice of Chief Minister Prem Kumar Dhumal's

swearing-in venue—the Ridge, the highest public spot in Shimla—on December 30. BJP's prime ministerial candidate L.K. Advani underscored the saffron surge by attending the ceremony and claiming that "the party is on a comeback trail". BJP won 43 seats in the 68-member Assembly. The Congress could retain only 21 seats—a loss of 22 seats to its 2003 election tally.

In a state where the political power has alter-

nated between the Congress and BJP for the last three decades, the poll outcome was on predictable lines. While BJP was quick to call it "a beginning of the countdown of the UPA Government", a crestfallen Congress tried to downplay the import of its double debacle.

Led by an aggressive campaign focusing on corruption and unemployment, BJP demolished the development card that Congress chief minister Virbhadra Singh had hung on to, to dodge the anti-incumbency sentiment fuelled by charges of corruption against him and his family. Singh's much-vaunted promise of providing job to one member of every family had also fallen flat.

As the victory euphoria wears thin, Dhumal will have to reckon with a phalanx of formidable challenges—providing employment to six lakh jobless youth and generating additional resources to push the cart of development. Clearly, his task is going to be steeply uphill.

by Ramesh Vinayak

SIGNPOSTS

INCLUDED: Delhi's **Akshardham Temple** in *The Guinness Book of World Records*, for being the world's largest Hindu temple complex.

DIED: G.P. Sippy, 93, who produced landmark films such as *Sholay*, *Seeta aur*



Geeta, *Shaan* and *Sagar*. He started his career in 1951 with *Sazaa*.

CHARGESHEETED: By the CBI, senior diplomat and former special secretary in the Ministry of External Affairs **Rakesh Kumar**, for his alleged involvement in human trafficking.

DIED: Senior Andhra Pradesh Congress leader **P. Janardhan Reddy**, 59, of cardiac arrest in Secunderabad. He was an MLA from Khairatabad constituency.

DIED: Congress MLA and freedom fighter **P. Bhaskaran**, 86. He represented Kannur constituency in Kerala.

VIS-A-VIS

RITA BAHUGUNA JOSHI UPCC chief **versus** **MAYAWATI** Uttar Pradesh chief minister

If Mulayam was bad, Mayawati is worse. She has not delivered on any front. Both are castiest and anti-social.



RAM

Congress, BJP and other parties have done nothing for the oppressed and downtrodden. Only BSP can solve the problems.

EPILOGUE: They all claim to have the solution, but the problems still remain.